Swapping in your custom UI art

How to replace the placeholder styling with your own artwork later, without breaking anything.

1. What is placeholder today

Piece	File	Styled with
Dialogue panel background	`scenes/dialogue.tscn` → `Panel`	StyleBoxFlat (dark blue, rounded) via Theme Overrides
Dialogue text	`dialogue.tscn` → `Panel/VBoxContainer/TextLabel`	font size 20, word-smart wrap
Speaker name	`dialogue.tscn` → `Panel/VBoxContainer/NameLabel`	default font
Choice buttons	created in code by `scripts/autoload/dialogue.gd`	default engine theme
Pause menu background	`scenes/pause_menu.tscn` → `Panel`	StyleBoxFlat
Pause title + buttons	`pause_menu.tscn`	font 28 title, default buttons
NPC "E" prompt	`scenes/npc.tscn` → `Prompt`	text "E", font 16, black outline

Yes, you can change the fonts at any time. Nothing in the scripts hardcodes a font — every font and size lives in the scenes as a Theme Override, so swapping them is a pure editor change.

2. Import your art

1. Create `assets/UI/` (and `assets/Fonts/`).
2. Drag your `.png` / `.ttf` / `.otf` files in. Godot imports them automatically.
3. For panel backgrounds, export **9-patch style** images: a small picture whose border pixels are designed to stretch while the corners stay sharp. A plain stretched photo will smear the corners.

3. Replace a panel background (dialogue or pause menu)

1. Open the scene, select the `Panel` node.
2. Inspector → **Theme Overrides** → **Styles** → **panel** → **New StyleBoxTexture**.
3. Click it, set **Texture** to your PNG.

4. Set the **margin values** (content margins) to keep the text padding you have now: dialogue: left/right 16, top/bottom 12. Pause: your choice.
5. Set **Texture margins** (the *Margin* row) to the thickness of your art's border so the corners don't stretch. This is what makes a 9-patch behave.
6. Do **not** touch anchors/offsets — only the style changes. Layout stays top-center.

4. Fonts

1. Import your `.ttf`/`.otf`.
2. Select the label (`TextLabel`, `NameLabel`, pause `Title`, `Prompt`).
3. **Theme Overrides** → **Fonts** → **font** → your FontFile.
4. Sizes stay in **Theme Overrides** → **Fonts** → **font_size** (20 dialogue text, 16 prompt, 28 pause title).
5. Optional global default: **Project Settings** → **GUI** → **Theme** → **custom_font** (or assign a Theme resource there) — applies everywhere that has no explicit override. Per-label overrides win.

5. Buttons (choices + pause menu)

- **Per button:** select it → Theme Overrides → Styles → `normal` / `hover` / `pressed` → New StyleBoxTexture → your art (same margin trick as step 3).
- **All buttons at once:** Project Settings → GUI → Theme → New Theme, set the Button styles in it, and pick it as the default. Style once, applies everywhere.

6. The NPC "E" prompt

Pick one:

- **Keep the Label (simplest):** import an icon font containing the key glyph, assign it as the font override on `Prompt`, change the text to that glyph. The blink animation keeps working.
- **Swap to an image:** change the `Prompt` node type from `Label` to `TextureRect`, set its Texture to your art, and update one line in `scripts/npc_scripts/npc.gd`: `@onready var prompt: Label = $Prompt` → `@onready var prompt: TextureRect = $Prompt`. Centering (anchors), `z_index = 10`, and the blink all still work.

7. Screen zones to respect (default 1152×648)

- **Dialogue panel:** centered, roughly x 276–876, y 20–176. Keep clear.
- **Top-left (x < 276):** reserved for health.
- **Top-right (x > 876):** reserved for future UI.
- **Pause menu:** covers the whole screen — no conflicts.

- Stretch mode is `canvas_items` + `expand`, so the dialogue stays centered at other window sizes; the side zones grow/shrink with the screen.

8. Do not change

- **Node names and paths:** `Panel`, `Panel/VBoxContainer`, `NameLabel`, `TextLabel`, `ChoiceBox`, `Prompt` — the scripts find them by path and will break otherwise.
- **Autoload names:** `GameState`, `Dialogue`, `PauseMenu`.
- **Anchor/grow values** on the dialogue `Panel` (top-center, grows downward) — layout, not style.
- The scripts (`dialogue.gd`, `npc.gd`, `pause_menu.gd`) — styling needs no code changes.

9. Quick check after each change

1. Run the game.
2. Walk to the NPC → the **E** blinks above its head.
3. Press **E** → panel appears top-center, text wraps, choices appear; declining and re-talking re-asks the question.
4. **Esc** during talk cancels the dialogue; **Esc** otherwise opens the pause menu.